“The Child Regret Department”

2004: The Taxi

When the pneumatic tube at the agency hisses and sends a new capsule to my station, I unlock it and unfurl the slip of paper inside, reading the names of my next two targets: Mom and Dad.

The day has come.

For many years, I watched the world descend into chaos, lives first celebrated and cherished, the next day worthless and erased in the blink of an eye. I told myself my erasure was inevitable like the promise of snow on a mid-winter’s night. All parents regretted their children in one way or another, the CRD merely capitalized on this universal secret. No number of memories of dimly lit happy birthday songs or hazy, sweet lullabies would make me an exception.

Make sure they never meet at the steakhouse, the note said.

When I arrive in 2004, I shoot a tranquilizer dart at a taxi driver and steal his car. Then I drive to pick up my target.

Now, as I drive through the streets of my home city Toronto, the stranger in the backseat of the car glances out her window, mesmerized by the glowing fairy lights of the night. The perfect evening for a first date.

I can’t tell her my identity. She talks about Dad as if finding him was her greatest achievement. They were both Filipino immigrants who met here. He’s going to be a delivery driver. She’s going to be a nurse. They talked about miraculous economic opportunity, the whimsies of fate, their hopeful and wondrous dreams.

From my time in the future, I know their destination. I’ve seen all the shattered plates and fights, heard every scream and slammed door. In my mind, I envision them signing their commission to the CRD. Then, my superiors in the boardrooms betraying me, assigning the task to me despite the conflict of interest, indifferent to the countless years I’ve worked for them. I held no doubt in the events that produced this moment, least of all for the decision of my parents. Yet, as I read my mission on the small screen of my watch, I can’t help it: my mind scrambles for logic, suspended between snapshots in time, little indicative moments when I had been a bad child.

2016 – 2036

“Don’t cheat on a test again,” said Dad, ripping the teacher’s note.

“This isn’t what we taught you.” My mother’s voice.

Dad opened the drawer, revealing my treasure trove of hours-woven creativity.

“She’s spending too much time drawing. That’s why she had to cheat on this test.”

“Just buy her one less sketchbook next month. To get her to start studying.”

A year later, Grandma’s illness got worse. Dad heard about the medical bill from the hospital from Manila and argued with Mom. I heard my name a few times. One day, he stormed into my room.

“Where are your drawings?”

Furious, he opened the cabinet and found them. Suddenly, he started tearing them apart, leaving none to spare. Mom found him as he finished tearing my favourite one: a pastel-coloured representation of the three of us holding hands that I titled, “My Family.”

“Vincent! What’s wrong with you?”

“I know how competitive the university programs here are. She needs to do better to stay

afloat so that when the time comes, she'll be ready."

"Don't say that. She's doing her best at school."

He shook his head and slammed my desk. "Rory! You need to do better. *Lola* is sick."

"Enough!"

They argued for the rest of the night. They pushed each other. Insults flew like missiles over borders of respect, temporary and intentional, later lied to be accidental and false. Buildings of emotion collapsed, strings of love shattered.

They yelled about me. *Careless. Liability. Trying her best. Not enough.* I covered my ears and retreated to my room. When I did, they argued more.

Later that night, Mom came into my room and held me, but I wasn't crying. Like them, I didn't choose this life, but they taught me what it meant for someone to sacrifice themself for a struggling family, that there could be greater priorities than the ephemeral dreams of a little child.

Time passed, and daydreams about art turned into nightmares of failed math tests, and collections of vibrant coloured pencils faded into an array of grey graphite.

#

It has been said that the direction of Time's Arrow is due to the increase of entropy.

With the advent of the CRD's technology, that is no longer true. A cup of tea can now get hotter over time, not just cooler. Broken glass can now be reassembled. But despite this new reality we lived in, we cannot change the way our minds compress moments of the past sequentially. I still play memories forward because it's all I know how to do.

"Okay class, today we're going to talk about what you want to be when you grow up."

One by one, we went around the circle. Policewoman. Firefighter. Businessman.

"Rory, it's your turn. What do you want to be when you grow up?"

I didn't hesitate. "A scientist who makes a lot of money."

"But you're always drawing!" a boy blurted. "And you're always close to failing on tests! How can you be a scientist when you're dumb?"

Everyone laughed, but I didn't hear them.

Mom and Dad's fights became more frequent. At night, I had nightmares about them splitting. I imagined myself abandoned with my teddy bear on the side of the road, lost and gone so quickly, unbearable summer heat searing my skin and my bare feet pebble-pierced at all angles.

Then I imagined an alternate version of me. Smarter, older, more confident. The best student in her class. The one my parents couldn't complain about.

I'm going to be her.

When I would wake up in the middle of the night, I would turn my desk light on. I slammed notebooks down and opened textbooks. Order of operations. Fractions. Matter and its properties. The water cycle. Ecosystems, electricity principles, geometry.

The days went by. I'm elated by fantasy. I wake up in a cold sweat.

#

Perhaps unsurprisingly, it is a difficult challenge to get reliable data on the number of parents who regret having children. The CRD does research of its own, but it has also compiled a list of surveys from history as special onboarding material for its new agents. When I'm out of commissions, I spend time learning.

In 1975, a Chicago Sun-Times advice columnist by the pen name of Ann Landers asked readers if, given the chance to go back in time and do it all over again, they'd still choose to have children. 10,000 people responded. The number of people who said they wouldn't was as high as 70%.

However, statistician David Bellhouse at the University of Western Ontario was skeptical, criticizing the voluntary nature of the poll as a textbook case of selection bias. His counterargument was simple: Is it not fairly predictable that the angry and hurt are more likely to respond? As the common saying goes, “Truly happy people don’t go around telling everyone that they’re happy.”

In 2013, Gallup conducted another poll that asked a similar question to Americans 45 years old and older, this time using random sampling: How many kids would you have if you could go back in time and change things? 7% of the respondents with children said zero.

Once more, scholarly debate on the topic often produced conclusions that marked another flaw: social desirability bias. The fact is, parents with children who explicitly say they regret having them essentially condemn themselves to social suicide. The joyful, ideal world is one where parents cherish their decision about their children every day of their lives. It is a tale reinforced by society, by the expectations of those around us, and even by legends and folklore.

I then wondered, what is the true statistic, then? Was this another unfortunately too common case of inconsistent and unattainable data, unavoidably altered by the fickle and impulsive mysteries of the human psyche?

At the end of my research, I got no definitive answers, but only final results. When I reached the more recent articles, modern studies had estimated that the number of parents who regret their children in countries with advanced economies hovered between 5% and 14%.

Even at its lowest figure, 5% of people in rich countries is a huge portion of the global population. I can see how, when entropy scientists engineered the ability to jump backwards in time in 2019, performing all the quality assurance tests to allow for stable alternate continuums, a corporation such as the Child Regret Department would rise to fill this massive market niche. It’s just the way of the world.

#

It’s my turn to bat. My bully was on my team, waiting for his turn behind me.

“Hurry up and hit the ball, we’re losing,” he groaned.

Strike.

“Seriously, Rory? Are you this bad at baseball too? Are your parents even proud of you?”

The rest of the team was getting impatient too. I clenched my fists until they turned white.

“I bet right now they’re commissioning the CRD to make sure you don’t exist!”

The kids listening around us laughed.

“Stop it! Please!”

I didn’t think. I gripped the bat and swung it wildly at him, cracking his nose and causing his blood to splatter in the dirt. He collapsed immediately.

Later, my parents were called to the teacher’s office.

“What happened?” asked Dad. This was the first time they were called to school for something I had done.

The teacher explained. “She and another boy got into a fight during gym class. The boy is fine; his nose will heal. But I’m worried for your daughter—she’s the sweetest girl I know. I never expected her to do something like this.”

The ride home was silent. Mom and Dad had nothing to say, but I knew they were ready to erupt anytime.

It happened at dinner.

“Why did you hurt the boy?” asked Dad. I was trembling.

When I didn’t answer, he stood up and his face flushed red. He pulled his belt and threatened to strike me if I didn’t say anything. I flinched and sobbed.

"Stop!" cried Mom, putting herself between us.

Then they argued furiously. I had to cover my ears.

At some point, I wasn't careful. I knocked over my glass of milk on the table, and the white liquid soaked into the tablecloth, spread around the plates of rice and *ulam*, and reached the edge and dripped to the floor. I cowered again, trying to sever my consciousness for what would happen next so I wouldn't have to experience it. I was prepared to die.

But this time, Dad didn't look angry, just disappointed. "*Bahala ka,*" he told me, standing up and leaving the room. *You're on your own.*

Mom sighed, went to grab a towel from the kitchen, and began to clean it up.

She had barely made any progress before she went limp on the ground, exhausted. She was so tired from work—from taking care of patients—she didn't have time for one more. She covered her head with her forearm.

"I don't know what to do with you anymore," she said.

#

In the ancient land of China, during the Shang dynasty, there lived a military commander named Li Jing and his wife, Lady Yin. After three years and six months of eagerly awaiting their baby, Lady Yin would finally give birth to their long-awaited child, but out would come a mysterious ball of flesh. Thinking it was a demon, Li Jing struck the ball with his sword. To everyone's astonishment, out sprang a fully grown boy who could speak. He bowed down and introduced himself as Nezha.

Year after year, as they raised their child, they discovered he did have a demonic nature. Unlike other kids his age, he possessed incredible strength and speed. Even without meaning to, he constantly injured kids when playing *jianzi* by kicking the shuttlecock too hard. When he got angry, he was rebellious at his core, often clashing with or disrespecting the authority of his parents.

It's a story about going against fate to change who you are. Nezha is demonic by nature; he can't help but be rebellious, even if he does love his parents. After accidentally smothering the East Sea Dragon King's son to death during a session of playfighting, the Dragon King threatened to flood all of China if he didn't gain retribution. To spare his village from the catastrophe and to free his parents from all the trouble he's caused them over the years, Nezha decides to commit suicide. It's seen as the ultimate story of filial piety and respect, and it's a lesson for all Chinese children to listen to their parents.

#

Hi honey, did you enjoy your birthday party with your friends?

It was the best party ever! Thanks for setting it up. I love you, Mom. If time travel is ever invented, I'll travel back to this moment, OK?

#

It was a cold January evening. I had stolen a toy from the store out of jealousy because everyone else had it at school. Mom had said she couldn't buy it for Christmas.

Dad was furious when he found out. He couldn't even look me in the eye.

I think about this story a lot in the idle moments between jumping eras. I'm weightless in the negentropy machine one moment in 1987. I'm gripping my tranquillizer the next during 2014.

"What about Santa?" I asked. "In class, the teacher made us write letters to Santa, and then she took care of sending them to the North Pole. All the other kids got the toy from Santa. I told Santa I wanted this toy too. How come he didn't bring it?"

In the future, the destination of this letter is explicable. But as a child, I allowed my mind

to soar into the wondrous universe of imagination, to delay the defeat that is maturity upon innocence. This was the stage of my life still full of little idiosyncrasies, until it perished to ruin in the instant of this moment. Her face was sad, but she was working hard not to look sad. Blink, and you'll miss it.

"I'm sorry, baby. Santa doesn't come to our house."

The truth was a gravity on my heart, and she hugged me fiercely. Then I'm back in the present, my watch beeping with the details of another mission. I have to go.

#

In 2036, the world's economy tanked, and high-paying jobs were hard to find. As I was getting desperate, a coworker who was dismissed along with me at our last company said he could help. He held a business card.

"They came to me when I was let go," he said. "What they do goes against my beliefs, so I refused. Luckily, I found another job, and I didn't have to take up their offer. But I told them I knew someone who might."

Before he gave me the card, he hesitated.

"Don't underestimate them, Rory. This isn't the same startup that we all knew when we were children. They're huge now. Working for them means you have to sign non-disclosure agreements and make sure no one in your life knows your real job. All their contractor agents make a fortune. Their math analysts make a decent amount, but I've heard their field agents are the wealthiest. If that's what you want, I'm sure they'll be happy to have someone with your skills. Just take the card and think about it."

The name on the card read Dr. Vivian Chao. I didn't have to think about it at all. She was my bridge across failure, my ticket to honouring the dreams of my parents.

2028

When I was at the end of high school, Grandma's condition worsened. She was all alone in Manila, and Dad had spent a long time trying to bring her here. He worked tirelessly to make it happen. Finally, the application was processed.

Mom entered my room to bring me the news.

"Your grandmother is visiting for the last two weeks of April. I don't want to put her downstairs where it's cold, so she's going to need your room. You will sleep in the basement instead."

I can't. It will throw me off my studies. I won't get into a good school.

I'm going to let them down.

I don't want to be a failure.

My mother looked around my room. Every once in a while, I would see her in here studying the walls that were once vibrant with my art. Lingering expressions of wanderlust enduring with nothing but a glimmer of hope for survival.

"You used to draw a lot when you were a kid," she muttered.

Grandma visited. I remember it being awkward. I hadn't seen her in a long time, not since I was very young, and she was practically a stranger. But when she saw me, she was impossibly full of joy, as if content with the sight of her thriving grandchild in a new country. I felt like an impostor.

"*Mahal kita, anak,*" she said, smiling.

She was downstairs and always needed someone to accompany her. I couldn't be the one to do it. Any time I spent with her felt unproductive, a waste of time.

"You shouldn't treat your grandmother that way," said Dad.

I didn't listen. I focused on math and physics instead. I used the last sketchbook they bought me to write more equations. Grandma died sometime during my last exam.

I got into the top school in the country.

2036 – THE PRESENT

"Your education is impressive. Polyglot. Political history. Psychology. Tech proficiency. We often need agents to blend in foreign environments, earn trust, and interpret local dynamics. Critical thinking skills and a general understanding of thermodynamics don't hurt as well. You'll fit right in."

After a long period, I finally met her. The manager who interviewed me was Dr. Vivian Chao, and I was eager to impress her. After we shook hands, I received an ID with my name on it: Rory Alonto. As a contractor, I wasn't allowed to know the internal details of the company's operations. I was briefed only on the information I needed to know.

"First, you must understand that the couples *must* split. There is no other way, and our clients must sign a contract so that they know this. We must ensure the parents never meet. We've done calculations, and we are certain that the soul remains with the same couple if you only preclude the conception."

"The soul?"

She nodded. "For lack of a better word, unfortunately. It's what we call the unit of life we tinker with when our scientists write their equations on the boards and run their simulated algorithms to learn about the alternate timelines. Since it's not your role, you don't have to worry about what they do. Calculations will be made to ensure this main timeline won't drastically change from the loss of our customers' romantic affairs, and the world will immediately adjust. Reality will change and everyone's memories of the couple will disappear. Life will go on."

Then she told me about the latest innovations of the company. The most significant one included an experimental soul-tracking technology that, when finished, would allow the CRD to track the souls of individuals who were precluded to learn about the new family they would be born to in the new timeline.

"It's far from perfect," she said. Then she smiled. "But we do our best."

What do you think is the reason all these parents regret their children? a coworker asked one day. *I know sometimes there are cases where precluding them is necessary. But the majority of our clients are normal people.*

I was defeated by curiosity. Later, I stole a keycard and entered a hallway forbidden to contractors. I accessed restricted network files without clearance, and I saw our clients and their reasons for their commissions to the CRD. One by one, the majority of them shared the same, single word in large, bold letters on the screen:

UNHAPPINESS…

The world was broken, and I was witnessing the proof. I fell asleep that night thinking of that word and all the children who think they're not enough.

#

Century after century, stories arise about heartless parents who reject their children. While peasants toiled in the fields, Hera was busy throwing her baby Hephaestus off Mount Olympus because he was born crippled. Surya, the Hindu sun god, was unhappy with his son Shani because of his dark complexion. Japanese gods Izanagi and Izanami gave birth to Hiruko, who was born without bones and was unable to stand at the age of three. They placed him in a boat and set him

adrift in the open ocean. In modern times, an eight-year-old boy named Gabriel Fernandez was abused and tortured over months by his own mother and stepfather, with alleged motivations that it was due to his perceived homosexuality.

The truth, at least to me, is obvious: not all parents love their children.

Whether this fact is more widespread than actually perceived will always remain a mystery. These stories cause us pain because of our innate condition to view them as unnatural. From a scientific standpoint, a species must continue to reproduce to ensure its survival. Caring for children is specifically essential for us since we can't run to the ocean to escape predators on the beach like turtles at birth, even if we want to. From a human standpoint, people socially trust other people to raise their children well. We have laws in place to prioritize that the custody of a child remains in the hands of their parents.

When the systems we set up fail and child protection services are needed, is it the fault of the government or human nature? Why is it that we need to create a job to ensure that one of the most inherent traits of our biology needs to be kept in check? It's like forming a police force to make sure alligators eat their prey. Do parents rely on genetic code for their desire to protect their children, or are they simply microcosms of the values of the world around them, sculpted by culture, sometimes forced to go against their will?

These questions are in my mind when a single woman tells me she'd rather have cats and be a "cool aunt," or when a man who is financially stable and is nearing 40 still does not have children and says that won't change anytime soon. Often, these people like to feel they have escaped the prison of mob mentality, that they have found a way to ascend above societal expectations. I'm awed at how easily they're able to do so.

Some people go against perceived biological truths, such as the *will to survive*, as evidenced by those who suffer from depression and commit suicide. However, the *will to survive* is not part of the scientific definition of life. So, although it is arguably a complex topic to challenge common conventions about life, it does not constitute a paradox in my mind. On the other hand, Darwinian evolution has defined reproduction as a core tenet of life. If some people fail to accomplish this task because they simply choose *not* to, how accurately can this definition of life be applied to them?

Perhaps we are more than scientific definitions. Evolution can't explain why we sometimes fear the prospect of children, or how it feels to hold Mom and Dad just because it's comforting.

#

Why does he always insist on giving me more rice from his plate? I can never finish it all.
Your dad didn't have much growing up. It's just his way of showing—
I hate it! Tell him to stop!

#

I ruined cars. I shut off the connections of destined long-distance daters before they met online. I dropped powerful laxatives in drinks at bars. With each precluding commission, I got paid.

The department's scientists understood well the calculus of these timelines, playing them like strings on a lyre, weaving new stories that stole lives and breathed them elsewhere. They understood something about the past and the future, about life and happiness, about the forces that propelled true living versus the destinations of regret. Love was in their equations. They knew how to pluck a single chokepoint in a person's continuum, how to turn a moment subtly altered into a crashing domino effect, how to turn one's whole life fleeting. It's in these moments that I have a job. I must trigger the event here or blow the wind the opposite way there. Births shuffle around

in this crowd of souls, orchestrated in giant labs of monitors at the company offices. I am a matcher of families.

The Child Regret Department expanded globally. Its services now reached clients from Hong Kong to Mexico City, from Buenos Aires to Berlin. I remember Tokyo getting one late. Others early, like Hanoi. Some places never, such as the Middle East. As the corporation grew, its effects on the population were undeniable.

Just a few days ago, everyone could have known a neighbour next door, but now we lived as if they never existed. There was no way to tell, other than the theories and math of the academic community.

"Maybe the modern world isn't built for children to last," a coworker said. "Maybe people live a thousand lifetimes with a thousand different partners, and each time, they regret their children and go to the CRD."

Some people protested and claimed they were lying, that there were no disappearing people. Others spread rumours that parents regretting children was a universal truth. The number of online podcasts and riots on the street skyrocketed, and the hot fires of debate engulfed nation after nation. The world was in disagreement.

The skeptics doubted that the CRD could preclude people's existence without their permission. But I worked for them, and I knew this was true. The corporation argued that since the children of their clients would never have existed in the new timeline, their consent was irrelevant.

"Like how we punish criminals for doing something they did in the past, we seek to prevent the suffering of the future," said Elara Moiridis, CEO of the Child Regret Department, during a press conference.

When the cameras flashed and the reporters swarmed her with questions about ethics, the edge of her jaw tightened.

"Corporations expand," she asserted. "Their views shift, their goals get twisted. When many hear about a big new company, they focus on what it has done, but do they ever ask what it first set out to do?"

As the world spiralled into more disorder, the number of phone calls to parents soared. People feared for their lives.

Every day now, whether on the internet or when I turn on the TV, I get an advertisement with gloomy music and fading scenes of silent streets, empty parks, and abandoned towns. Sometimes, a seesaw creaks in a quiet corner with no children on it, as the rustling leaves blow in the wind.

2004: The Taxi

Back in the taxi with my mother, I drive and take in the sights of the world of 2004. The streets of the city are alive. People are walking on the road, entering movie theatres, laughing on benches, and chatting on phone calls. Cars honk in heavy traffic. None of them see the moment as fleeting, the world as fragile as paper in a rainstorm, destined for the reign of the Child Regret Department.

My hands grip the wheel. Every wrong turn I make is a childhood memory gone, every street away from the steakhouse a year escapes my life.

"You look Filipino," my mother says.

She talks about her life in Manila. The arguments between her mother and father. A miserable life in a household with a family beyond repair, forced to remain united for their seven children. Stories I heard growing up from the same lips, but older.

My mother continues. “We had a lot of trouble growing up. But I love my *kuyas* and *ates*, and my *nanay* and *tatay,* and I wouldn’t have it any other way. Filipinos emphasize never divorcing. Do you know what Filipinos think is the saddest thing in the world? For a child to grow up without two parents who love each other. Sometimes, life gives us only one chance, and we have to get it right.”

For millennia, the parents of the world carried this burden without a choice. Though it was an impossible task, they only had one chance, and mistakes were not allowed, lest they cascade the consequences of those mistakes in the future. The Child Regret Department removed the preciousness of this one chance, eliminating this lack of choice that has tormented us since time immemorial. Then it demanded loyalty to this cause, claiming science was the solution to creating the best children.

Tears rise from the brims of my eyes. I do my best to look away so Mom won’t see.

The roads of the city, once a boundless labyrinth of infinite, equally unimportant paths, become a map with a single meaningful destination. Suddenly, where I am driving matters.

I am reminded of a Latin phrase I read during my CRD onboarding period, *Amor fati,* a philosophical concept that means “a love of one’s fate.” They teach it to us because everything we do at the company goes against it. We go against the enthusiastic principles of Friedrich Nietzsche, delighted as we reject his affection for the will of the cosmos. We edit the stream of entropy and let cigarette smoke back into the cigarette, let collapsing stars regain their breath for another day, let the spilled milk of an apologetic child clean itself up and slip back into the glass, an invisible force turning it back upright.

Our minds are wired to think mechanistically, but with the CRD’s new technology, we proved that life could be teleological, that the Arrow of Time isn’t only pushed forward, but it could be magnetically pulled from the arrow’s end as well.

When I choose to remember the good instead of the bad, my perspective shifts like the reversal of gravity. I’m no longer pulled down by the Earth. I look to the stars and see that all of us are headed away on this rocky spaceship, and I’m on the underside of it, being pulled upwards along with everyone else on this side of the globe.

She wouldn’t miss this date for the world, knowing how much she’d love my father in the coming years. It will all fade into ruin, but don’t we all?

The present

“I’m glad you made peace with your parents.”

Dr. Chao was initially confused when I came to work this morning, exiting the negentropy machine, still alive.

“When they ordered this commission, we disclosed the confidential information that you worked for us; it’s part of our legally binding contracts. Then we were surprised when they specifically chose you as their agent. They said you would do it in a heartbeat. So we obliged. Considering how fast you accepted the commission, we thought we made the right decision. Looks like we were wrong.”

I shake my head. “I may have saved our family, but I will never change the fact that I didn’t make them proud enough to keep me. I’ll be the constant living reminder of their failed creation.”

“What do you mean?”

Genuine confusion, then her sparks fly.

“Rory, I think you’ve got it all wrong. Have you heard the biblical story that inspired the original founders of the CRD?”

I tell her I haven't.

She continues. "King Solomon once had two women and a single baby come up to him. Both women claimed the baby to be theirs. To figure out who was the true mother and who was just trying to hurt the other and didn't care about the baby at all, he said he would order his men to cut the baby in half, and each woman would receive one half."

"What happened?"

She smiles. "One woman agreed. One woman begged King Solomon to give the other woman the baby instead. It was then he knew who the real mother was. Rory, our clients—they don't regret the child from a love long lost. They regret what *could have been*. That's what the Child Regret Department is all about."

When she leaves, I look once more at the company database files. The same word, *UNHAPPINESS,* is still displayed on each client file as their stated reason for the commission. Then I discover the details are expandable; each one has three dots I can click on for more to read. One by one, I open each file, reading the same line over and over:

UNHAPPINESS FOR THE CHILD.

"*No matter what you do in life, we love you. -Mom and Dad,*" my parents wrote in their client file. Then, some instructions for the company: *When she precludes us, and your research division tracks down the new parents her soul is born to, write this in a note and give it to them. Tell them to plant it inside the first sketchbook they buy her, so they can do a better job than we ever could.*

Below is a section where the CRD allows parents to submit photos so they can capture their child's living memory. As I scroll, I find pictures of all the pieces of artwork I've made over the years. There are hundreds of them. There are pictures of my sketchbook's pages scattered across my room, sketches on napkins I've made at restaurants, even the lone doodles on my failed math tests. When I scroll further, I see addresses of art schools, notes on their meetings with art professors, a glass jar full of cash labelled *For Rory.* At the end: thumbprint-smeared pieces of my artwork, "My Family," that my father had done his best to tape back together.

I didn't complete my mission. But I imagine myself in an alternate universe if I had—the CRD scientists using their tweezers to collect the pieces of my soul like fragments of a collapsing supernova, gently placing the final product in the room of a house under two new parents. The textbooks and pinned formulas on bulletin boards disappear, replaced by canvases and paintbrushes sprinkled on the floor. The note my parents wrote is now pinned against the wall, next to the works I've propped up. My imagination remains bright and infinitely wondrous, full of colour and splashes of paint and worlds never before seen. Blink, and you'll miss it.

But the colour of the room is different, and I don't want that. And so I blink, and as I think of my own parents, a welcome smile engages my lips, relieved it's only what could have been.